

THE OBJECT IN THE LOCKER: DISPOSITION .

2026-09-08

Two independent generators (Fable, ...-fable-2026-09-08.md; ChatGPT, ...-gpt-2026-09-08.md) answered the same nine-requirement brief. This table is the check, run against the brief and against the ruled spine (v1.4 with v1.5 to v1.7) rather than against either author's own ranking. Stephen rules. Nothing here is approved until he does.

Two canon facts that change the reading

- "The cupboard" is the locker.** Spine v1.5 fixes "the cupboard" of Margo's message (row 77) as Violet's locker store at the boatsheds, and D3 calls the two letters "the cupboard letters". Margo's "the thing in the cupboard is wrong" can therefore be about the letter, which under vo.3 it is (her lock is the omission of the debts). The object does not have to carry the Tessa message on its own. Requirement 7 was over-asked; a candidate that meets it is welcome, a candidate that meets it by dragging the money to the table is not.
- The mother died at Day -1500, about four years before Day 0.** Liam drove them in on the last night and knows the night, not the cash (row -1500). Violet has a sister who does not know about the cash. Any object of the mother's has been in Violet's house four years, which is long enough for all four to know it on sight and long enough that its position is a habit.

The gates

A: needs the locker (not postable to one of them; not keepable in an entered house). B: absence undatable (Day 0 removal; three weeks no visitors; police photographs Day 1). C: proves intrusion without accusing. D: the room can infer Liam; the letter never says so. E: the survivors' silence nine months on is believable (survivors are Liam and Ruby; Margo is dead by Day 214; Brad vanished Day 51). F: Margo's beat, if any, keeps the money out of the room. G: never Brad, never money owed, never Tessa. H: tone (no ghost, no thriller, no bathos). I: fits canon as ruled.

#	Candidate	Fails	Verdict
F1	Mother's mantel clock, found going	H (a clock that starts itself is a ghost story; Fable names it). Also an arithmetic flaw: the clock is in Brad's hands from Day 0 to the swap morning, so "stopped at the hour she fell" is something Brad would have to set deliberately, which is one cruelty too many. And her own letter says "I don't wind that clock", so a running clock in the locker contradicts the letter unless the intruder wound it and she locked it running.	Second, with the ghost risk owned
F2	Mother's ashes, turned on the shelf	Nothing structural. A: the only candidate where a padlocked locker is not merely natural but the only decent place, and where posting is unthinkable. B: a scatter tube on a back-bedroom shelf; the police photograph a shelf with a book on it. C: "facing the door" is exactly the size of oddity the letter needs, real enough to frighten and small enough that "or I'm imagining it" survives. D: Liam asked to take her out on his boat (a true item Brad can put on the starter list in her voice; Liam drove them in on the last night, row -1500, so his asking is in character). E: the strongest of the twenty; nobody will tell a podcaster they kept her mother in a cupboard and read her position like tea leaves. F: Fable's maiden-name beat brings the mother's house within a sentence of the money; strike the beat, keep the object; the Tessa message is carried by the letter under vo.3. H: gothic if pushed; flat if played flat. I: fits; four years unscattered is more in character than one.	First

#	Candidate	Fails	Verdict
F3	Boxing Day brandy	G and H. The second lowering in Margo's cupboard has only two explanations, evaporation or Tessa, and the brief bars Tessa. A nurse says "loose stopper" at meeting two.	Out
F4	Mother's 78 record	A (a disc is postable to one of them) and it needs a real, clearable song. Margo's "buying her mother back" is the best private discovery in either set and goes to the idea bank.	Out; salvage the discovery
F5	School teapot, glued	A and H (bathos; a teapot does not need steel). The "she was imagining it" turn is good and can be given to another object.	Out; salvage the turn
F6	Mother's hospice stick at the stair head	It sends the room to the police against the letter's instruction; it makes the stairs a murder in week one.	Out
F7	Slate house sign	F and G (names the house; the house is the money) and it is a lettered board from her hall, one step from the rejected object.	Out
F8	Carving knife	H (thriller); a blade behind a padlock asks for police.	Out
F9	Morphine tin	D (the arrow swings to Ruby the nurse); adds "Violet was ill" to canon; "tin" collides with the tobacco tin.	Out
F10	Gold leaf	G (the one object a second signwriter would want).	Out
G1–G10	GPT's ten as a family	Every one of GPT's ten is a container of the mother's with cash, a cash wrapper, a cash envelope or a cash band inside it, and every Margo beat is the same sentence: "the wrapper is part of the single cache, so it cannot prove later payments by Liam". That reading requires the room to have been discussing money passing between Liam and Violet by meeting three. Money in the room is exactly what vo.3 forbids: Margo's lock is the letter's silence about the debts, and a cash tin on the table ends that silence in the first minute (who did she lend to; the largest debtor is sitting there). GPT's own fail line on G1 is decisive: "it fails if Margo has no compelling reason to withhold the truth the moment the tin is opened." She has none. G1 and G8 also collide with the tobacco tin by name.	Out as a family
G6	GPT's clock (broken, in a cupboard, with a wrapper inside)	As above, plus GPT's own fail: four people recognising a broken clock kept in a cupboard is arranged.	Out

What the two generators agree on

- Both independently produced the mother's mantel clock (F1, G6). Convergence says the object is intuitive; the gates say the ghost version and the cash version both fail. If the ashes is ruled too dark, the clock is the fallback, played as a stopped clock found wound and then let run down, never as a clock that "started".
- Both agree the locker is justified by only three things: size, value or meaning. GPT chose value ten times and paid for it with money in the room. Fable's best candidates chose meaning.
- Both agree a physical sign of handling (turned, opened, moved) beats a missing thing. Under vo.3 the sign must be small enough to doubt.

Recommendation

The object in the locker is her mother's ashes, in the plain crematorium scatter tube, four years unscattered on the back-bedroom shelf. The forged letter, in her voice: "Mum is in the locker. She was on the shelf facing the window and on the ninth she was facing the door. I do not turn her. I am not leaving her in a house I can't say is empty." Brad carries out something the size of a biscuit tin on Day 0 and nobody can ever

date its absence. Liam's two requests to take her out on the boat go on the starter list as a true item, and the room does the rest.

Costs, stated plainly.

1. Tone is a knife edge. One word of "ghost" or one line of grief theatre and it goes gothic. The rule for every brief: the tube is handled like luggage and spoken of like a person, and nobody at the table describes it.
2. The writers must know, and the close must eventually say, where she is now. Proposed for the ruling, not ruled: the survivors have not scattered her; Liam still has the boat. That is a close-of-episode beat, not a chapter 1 fact.
3. The sister exists (row –1500) and would have a view on her mother's ashes. One line of canon needed: the mother left it to Violet, or the sister asked for nothing.
4. Fable's Margo beat (the maiden name on the label) is struck. It brings the house to the table. Under vo.3 Margo's turn is the omission of the debts, and the object needs no second turn.
5. Replaces the board in spine rows 5b, 31 and R16 (the empty hook and the pale rectangle become nothing; the police photograph a shelf). The survivors' account "she took it down herself" becomes "she moved Mum herself, she said so in the letter", which is stronger.

Fallback if the ashes is ruled too dark: the mother's mantel clock, with Fable's engineered coincidence removed: she let it run down after the funeral; on the ninth it had been wound; she stopped it and locked it away, and her letter says so.

Salvage to the idea bank

- A woman quietly buying her mother's things back one at a time (F4's Margo discovery).
- The oldest mend in the house read as new by frightened people (F5's turn).
- A 78 the survivors will not let a podcast play (F4's silence).

Addendum, same day: the two treatments side by side

Stephen could not rule between the ashes and the clock without seeing them play. Two fresh Fable agents were given the same nine-station brief, differing only in the object: ...-treatment-ashes-2026-09-08.md and ...-treatment-cLock-2026-09-08.md, both verbatim. Same guard rails in both: no money in the room, Margo's turn stays the omission of the debts, no ghost language, no grief theatre.

Station	The ashes	The clock
1 Letter paragraph	"Somebody has been in the back bedroom, or I have started moving things and forgetting." Locks her away because someone stood and looked.	"Somebody had wound it. I stopped it. I did not want to be in the house with it ticking." Locks it away because it ticked.
1 Starter line	Liam asked in March and July to take her out on the boat; "he did not ask why, and I did not say."	Liam cannot walk past a stopped clock, has sat under this one four years and never touched it; "I have wondered what that costs him."
2 The locker	Margo: "She's brought her mum." Brad hands Ruby the letter and lets Liam be the one who reaches.	Liam: "I know whose it is." Lifts it dial inward "the way you carry a thing that might spill". Brad's hands stay in his jacket.
3 Between meetings	Ruby's sideboard, label to the wall because Liam set it down that way. Nobody decided.	Ruby's sideboard behind Liam's chair. Brad sets the rule: "Nobody winds it."

Station	The ashes	The clock
4 The table	The room reaches Liam through a kindness (he offered so she would not have to decide) plus his honest answer about the window catch. Margo underlines "Spring".	The room reasons: an eight-day clock is not wound in passing, so not a burglar, so someone who thought it a shame stopped. Liam: "You think I'd stand in her front room and wind it?" Nobody answers.
5 Margo alone	Turns the label out, looks, turns it back because it was not hers to touch. Costs nothing; cuttable.	Opens the back: the winding key is on its hook inside. The clock points at nobody; the page does the pointing. The best beat in either treatment, and it costs nothing.
6 Ruby's refusal	Custody: "She put it there for us to mind, and I'm still minding it." Warns Ally off Liam, which tells her Liam would talk. Ally learns from the sister: "she was not on the shelf."	Stewardship: "you're the police with better manners." Ally hears "what was in" not "what it said". Learns from the pale rectangle plus the sister's probate list.
7 The turn	"The tube never pointed at Liam. Brad did, and used her to do it." Liam: "I carried her to the car for him."	"The clock was never evidence; it was casting." Brad wound it himself on the ninth to see whether she would write it down. Liam: "I carried it out for him."
8 The close	Ruby rings the sister; the sister asks Liam. Three of them take the boat out; the sister cannot, so Liam does it, downwind, at the point.	Liam sets it on his own mantel, hands where Violet left them, key on its hook. He does not wind it, and now everyone knows why.
9 Breaks named	Brad takes it before he knows a locker exists; sentiment under pressure across nine scenes; the room convicts a kindness on two leaning coincidences. Ship with a plain on-the-night reason.	The ninth must fall after the last visitor and before the store letter; the sister's probate list makes the four withholders of estate property; the clock trait is Liam's only trait, so genre readers see the plant. Ship with the date pinned.

Two findings that belong to the spine, not to either object.

1. **Brad's foreknowledge on Day 0.** Both treatments put the same crack under the object, and it is already under v8.1's board: Brad takes the decoy at 22:20 on Day 0 (row 94), but the notes are posted Day 12 and rows -18 to -1 read "nothing visible". Why does he carry an object out of the house a fortnight before he learns there is a locker to dress? Proposed fix, one row, and it strengthens the whole: the debt book is her book of everything, and Brad reads it that night. In it, in her hand: padlock changed, four keys cut on Lantern Street, envelopes lodged with the solicitor, "letter and the thing in the store". He learns on Day 0 that a letter exists and where, and he takes an object because he already knows he will have to replace what is beside it. This makes the Day 14 forgery a plan begun on Day 0 rather than an improvisation, and it makes the debt book's burning (row 108) matter twice.
2. **"The ninth" must be pinned.** Whatever the object, the forged paragraph dates an intrusion and a move. The date must fall after the last time any of the four was in her house and before Day -19, when the true letter went into the store. One date, chosen once, and the standing check (nothing in a key letter may date the store letter) still passes because the key letters do not mention it.

My read of the two, for the ruling. The clock plays cleaner at the table: winding an eight-day clock is a deliberate act, so the room's reasoning is sound and not sentimental, and Margo's key-on-the-hook beat is the best single moment in either sketch. But the clock is weak on the one gate this whole round was called for: she stopped it, so a locker is a choice rather than a necessity, and "I did not want to be in the house with it ticking" is answered by "then don't wind it". The ashes is absolute on that gate, gives Ally the best discovery ("she was not on the shelf"), gives Liam the episode's closing act instead of a mantelpiece, and makes the room's crime the exact one v0.3 is about: they convicted the kindest man at the table for a kindness. Its cost is tonal and it is paid in every scene. I still recommend the ashes, and I would take the clock's Margo beat with it in spirit: her one private look is at the thing that points at nobody.

The ruling is Stephen's.

RULED 2026-09-08 (provisional): the ashes

Stephen: "Let's go with the ashes for now." The object in the locker under v0.3 is her mother's ashes in the crematorium scatter tube, as played in . . . -treatment-ashes-2026-09-08.md, with these carried into the v0.3 delta as proposals: Brad learns of the store and the notes from the debt book on Day 0 (spine fix, both objects needed it); "the ninth" pinned to a date after the last visitor and before Day -19; one line on why the ashes were Violet's to keep; Fable's maiden-name beat struck; Margo's one private look kept in spirit (a quarter turn of the label). "For now" means the clock stays on file as the fallback until v0.3 has survived two adversaries.